

Chapter 45-3

//

Liang Shi's treasured skills weren't forgotten—the eight-inch cake she baked smelled much more sweetly fragrant than the small cake from last time.

Because last time was for Ling Dang to eat, and considering the child's health, Liang Shi hadn't dared put in too much sugar.

But this time Liang Shi used all the right ingredients generously.

She even made her own piping bag at home, spread a light layer of cream on the cake, and then made decorations.

The appearance was even more beautiful than what dessert shops sold.

There was honeydew jam in the refrigerator, which happened to be green, so she used it to draw bamboo.

Bamboo swaying in the wind, complementing the white cream, looked both dynamic and serene.

Although Xu Qingzhu had been convincing herself to accept that this person had a new skill every day, she was still surprised when she saw this cake.

Yes, it was good enough to open a dessert shop with.

The cream was sweet but not cloying, the cake base was fluffy and delicious, the sweetness just right—better than what she'd bought at dessert shops before.

Dinner naturally couldn't consist of just cake, so while waiting for the cake to bake, Liang Shi made nourishing congee.

She put in peanuts, goji berries¹, and walnuts, and while the congee was cooking, she also stir-fried a vegetable dish.

Enough for two people to eat.

And Liang Shi's cooking was very much to Xu Qingzhu's taste.

After eating, Xu Qingzhu was responsible for cleaning up.

But she discovered that Liang Shi had already finished washing all the utensils used for making the cake.

Looking at the cleaned prep counter, she couldn't help but admire Liang Shi's thoughtfulness.

Standing at the sink, she couldn't help but turn back to look at Liang Shi wiping the table.

That thought appeared inappropriately again: Who is she?

—It seemed unimportant.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head and turned on the faucet, letting the gentle water flow over her fingers.

It didn't matter who she was—as long as their "roommate" life together was pleasant, that was enough.

//

After cleaning up the table, Xu Qingzhu sat on the sofa with Liang Shi to watch a movie.

It was a new release, a blockbuster that had just finished its theatrical run not long ago.

Even Xu Qingzhu, who was a "movie desert²," knew the name of this film: "Chang Bai³."

In recent years, there had been many xianxia⁴-genre TV dramas, but very few movies.

Firstly, the xianxia worldview was vast, making it difficult to tell a complete story within two hours;

Secondly, many scenes required post-production CGI, demanding high standards for both actors and post-production. To hire an excellent post-production team inevitably cost a lot of money, making production costs high.

Most xianxia movies lost money.

How could they compare to the stability of making TV dramas?

But "Chang Bai" was the dark horse that emerged at the box office recently.

When xianxia TV dramas were dominant, a xianxia movie without much backing quietly premiered.

The strongest promotional point was the female lead, Yang Shuyan.

As a veteran actress known for her acting skills and an established movie queen, Yang Shuyan's acting was universally recognized in the industry. She had burst into public view years ago with a film called "Wind Stops," and her explosive acting ability combined with the character's filter earned her a large fanbase.

All the productions she'd been in over the years never disappointed her fans.

Even so, the film production was so poor they couldn't afford any publicity.

For the first two days after release, the box office was dismal, but two days later, a famous film blogger wrote a review of "Chang Bai" with genuine emotion, even voluntarily giving away a hundred movie tickets in a giveaway, swearing to audiences that not going to theaters to see "Chang Bai" was everyone's loss.

So "Chang Bai" became a box office dark horse thanks to word-of-mouth from audiences, with screening times increasing daily.

Xu Qingzhu knew about this film because of Yang Shuyan.

During that period, reports related to this movie frequently appeared online.

Both were quiet while watching the movie.

Liang Shi was busy observing Yang Shuyan's acting skills, while Xu Qingzhu watched for entertainment. She had always been this way—when reading books or watching movies, she never voiced opinions midway. If she truly had deep insights about something, she would write a review after finishing.

What made this film most famous was still Yang Shuyan's red costume.

The blackened female protagonist was a demoness feared by all, but when Yang Shuyan put on the red robes, her presence commanded attention—so cool it was extraordinary, playing a villain character as both righteous and evil, making it impossible for people to hate her.

In the latter half of the movie, every time Yang Shuyan appeared on screen was shocking.

Her makeup and styling were impossibly beautiful, and her acting was indeed remarkable, even better than Zhao Ying by several degrees.

It completely drew people into following her performance.

Liang Shi thought back to seeing Yang Shuyan during the audition that day. Although she was also a cool older sister type, the feeling she gave off was completely different from what she conveyed in the movie.

It even made it impossible to connect her with the person in the film.

All xianxia dramas had grand themes—the fate of nations, all living beings under heaven.

But "Chang Bai" abandoned this approach, focusing everything on personal ideals.

Love and hatred, the fate of all under heaven—none could compare to her personal ideals.

She was someone both righteous and evil.

She didn't abandon the common people, nor did she abandon her lover, but ultimately chose her personal ideals.

When all choices were placed before her, there were only three words—"I want it all."

How domineering!

This kind of dominance, placed in the entertainment industry, would be difficult for anyone to portray to perfection.

But Yang Shuyan pulled it off.

When watching movies, Liang Shi usually put herself in the position of an observer. Because she was studying, she wouldn't put herself in as an audience member, as that made it too easy to get drawn in.

So she always imagined herself as the director, thinking about which shots looked better, which plot points were more moving, whether the script's turning points felt forced.

But unexpectedly, while watching the second half, she found herself caught up in the protagonist's surging emotions along with her.

Yang Shuyan's acting was truly shocking.

Footnotes: ¹ Goji berries: Also known as wolfberries, these are small red berries commonly used in traditional Chinese medicine and cooking, believed to have health benefits ² Movie desert: A Chinese internet slang term for someone who rarely watches movies or is not well-versed in film culture ³ Chang Bai: Likely refers to Changbai Mountain, a significant mountain range on the China-North Korea border, often featured in Chinese mythology and xianxia literature ⁴ Xianxia: A genre of Chinese fantasy fiction featuring immortals, martial arts, and supernatural elements, literally meaning "immortal heroes"